

SOP-LV-032 — Manual Material Handling & Safe Lifting

Reducing Strain Injury from Cable Spools, Ladders, and Equipment

SOP NUMBER	SOP-LV-032
TITLE	Manual Material Handling & Safe Lifting
EFFECTIVE DATE	July 25, 2026
REVISION	1.0
APPLIES TO	All Apex field technicians — Ontario & Manitoba
CATEGORY	Manual Handling & Ergonomics

1. Purpose

This procedure establishes safe lifting and material-handling practices for Apex technicians, covering cable spools, ladders, and tools and equipment — among the highest-frequency sources of injury in the trade.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all manual material handling performed by Apex technicians on any jobsite.

3. Assess Before You Lift

Before lifting anything unfamiliar, check the weight, size, and shape, and plan your path — including doors, stairs, and obstacles. If you have to ask whether you need help, get help.

4. Proper Lifting Technique

- Feet shoulder-width apart, close to the load.
- Bend at the knees, not the back — keep your spine as neutral as possible.
- Keep the load close to your body throughout the lift.
- Avoid twisting your torso while carrying — turn your feet instead.
- Lift smoothly; never jerk or snatch a load upward.

5. Team Lifts

- Communicate a lift count out loud (“one, two, three, lift”) so both people move together.
- Match pace with your partner — don’t outpace them on stairs or turns.
- Use a dolly or hand truck whenever one is available instead of a team carry.

6. Cable Spool Handling

- Use a spool jack or reel stand for large spools — never lift a full spool by hand alone.

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- Roll spools on their edge across flat ground rather than carrying them where possible.
- Get help or mechanical assistance for any spool loaded into or out of a van.

7. Ladder Carrying

Carry ladders parallel to your body with the front end raised slightly, watching for overhead obstructions, doorways, and bystanders — see SOP-LV-009 for full ladder handling and setup guidance.

8. Repetitive Motion Awareness

- Rotate repetitive tasks with a partner where possible.
- Take short breaks during repetitive or physically demanding work rather than pushing straight through.
- Report early signs of strain — don't wait for it to become an injury.

9. Prohibited Practices

- Never lift beyond your own safe capacity alone — get help or use equipment.
- Never carry a load that blocks your view of the path ahead.
- Never lift with a twisted or bent-sideways torso.

10. Reporting

Report any strain, sprain, or lifting-related discomfort to your supervisor the same day, even if it seems minor — early reporting leads to faster recovery and helps identify tasks that need a safer method.

11. Regulatory References

- Ontario Occupational Health and Safety Act, s. 25 — general duty (ergonomic hazards fall under general duty; Ontario has no fixed numeric lifting limit in regulation)
- CSA Z1004 — Workplace Ergonomics
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Act, C.C.S.M. c. W210 — general duty provisions

12. Related Apex Documents

- SOP-LV-009 — Ladder Safety — Commercial & Residential
- SOP-LV-HSK-001 — Jobsite Housekeeping

13. Revision History

Rev.	Date	Description	Approved By
1.0	Jul 25, 2026	Initial release	P. Cimini

This document is proprietary to Apex and is intended for internal use by Apex technicians and supervisors. Effective date: July 25, 2026.